the way, I could now watch the other sorties and jumpers more peacefully. Each trooper has to carry out five jumps to qualify for the coveted Wings, including a jump with full equipment and a night jump. My friends and I did those over the next week or so, maintaining a log of every jump. Having qualified, we were also now entitled to para-allowance, an extra Rs 300 per month, which was a bonus. To continue drawing this allowance, two refresher jumps have to be done each year, but unfortunately, my turn for that never came.

8 SIKH LI, commanded by Col SK Agarwal, was located in a field area in Assam. It was under 311 Infantry Brigade, part of 5 Mountain Division, which had its operational role in the Tawang Sector of Arunachal Pradesh. However, due to pressing internal security requirements, one Brigade, namely 311 Infantry Brigade, had been detached and given to 21 Mountain Division, which looked after IS duties in the whole of Assam. The situation prevailing at that time was quite poor due to the depredations of various terrorist groups, including the United Liberation Front of Assam (ULFA), National Democratic Front of Bodoland (NDFB), Dima Halim Daogah (DHD) and many others. 8 SIKH LI did not have any 2iC posted and had requested one. That's how a little over a year into my tenure with the SFF, I was transferred to this Battalion, with the aim of eventually taking over the same Battalion once Col Agarwal completed his tenure. In any case, Vivek was already present in Lucky Seven and slated to take over, so I would have had to move out anyway.

7 SIKH LI was also getting ready to move out for its field posting, so rather than continue at Meerut, we decided to shift to Delhi, with Veena, Isha and Amala staying with Veena's parents at Vasant Kunj. It would also be more convenient for me whenever I came on leave. We admitted Isha and Amala to

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